

Question Bank — Week 3

Recursion · data structures and classes in Python (Lecture 03, Lab 03) — Answers

DSA27 · Data Structures and Algorithms

Fall 2026

Questions: *week03-questions.md*. Commit to your own answer before reading one here.

Part A — Multiple choice

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
M01	a	M08	c	M15	d	M22	d
M02	d	M09	b	M16	c	M23	b
M03	b	M10	a	M17	a	M24	c
M04	c	M11	d	M18	b	M25	b
M05	a	M12	c	M19	d	M26	d
M06	d	M13	b	M20	c		
M07	b	M14	a	M21	a		

W3-M01 — a. A base case that answers directly, and progress towards it. A loop (b) is not needed; one recursive call (c) is enough; a global counter (d) is a debugging aid, not a requirement.

W3-M02 — d. $-1, -2, -3, \dots$ moves *away* from the base case 0, so the calls never stop until Python's depth limit. `ValueError` (c) is what the exercise version should raise — by checking $n < 0$ explicitly.

W3-M03 — b. `sys.getrecursionlimit()` is 1,000 by default.

W3-M04 — c. $n + 1$ frames are on the stack at the deepest point (n down to 0). Space is decided by the depth, not by the answer's size (d).

W3-M05 — a. Unroll: c is added once per halving, $\log_2 n$ times.

W3-M06 — d. The number of calls doubles at every level: $1 + 2 + 4 + \dots + 2^{n-1}$.

W3-M07 — b. $cn + c(n-1) + \dots + c = cn(n+1)/2$.

W3-M08 — c. $2^5 - 1 = 31$.

W3-M09 — b. Each item is either in or out: $2^4 = 16$. (24 (c) is $4!$, the number of permutations.)

W3-M10 — a. $4! = 4 \times 3 \times 2 \times 1 = 24$.

W3-M11 — d. `fib(5)` calls `fib(4)` and `fib(3)`, and so on: the recursion tree has 15 nodes. (In general $2 \text{fib}(n+1) - 1$.) 8 (b) is the *value* `fib(6)`.

W3-M12 — c. Two calls on $n/2$: $T(n) = 2T(n/2) + c = O(n)$. Compute the half power **once**, store it, and square the variable: $O(\log n)$.

W3-M13 — b. Each call copies the rest of the list: $(n-1) + (n-2) + \dots = O(n^2)$ — the hidden loop from Lecture 02.

W3-M14 — a. Solve each subproblem once, store its answer (for Fibonacci, in an Array indexed by n), and look it up afterwards.

W3-M15 — d. Frames are popped as calls return; the deepest chain is `hanoi(20) → hanoi(19) → ... → hanoi(1)`: about 20 frames. The *total* number of calls is exponential; the *depth* is linear.

W3-M16 — c. Each call prints n on the way **down**, then again on the way **back up**, after the inner call has returned: 3 2 1 then 1 2 3.

W3-M17 — a. The empty set has exactly one subset — itself. Returning `[]` (b) means “no subsets”, and every result built from it is then empty too.

W3-M18 — b. Python deliberately keeps every frame (it keeps `tracebacks` complete). Deep recursion should become a loop.

W3-M19 — d. `sort()` sorts in place and returns `None`. `sorted(marks)` returns the new list.

W3-M20 — c. `{}` is an empty dictionary; an empty set is `set()`.

W3-M21 — a. A set is a hash table: average $O(1)$ membership. A list would be $O(n)$.

W3-M22 — d. `tricks` is a **class** variable: one list shared by every instance. Create per-object data in `__init__`: `self.tricks = []`.

W3-M23 — b. The body only starts running when `next()` is called — by a `for` loop, `list()` and so on.

W3-M24 — c. Every remaining item shifts one place left. Use `collections.deque` in plain Python — or, in this course, your own `CircularQueue` (Week 7).

W3-M25 — b. `get(w, 0)` supplies 0 for a missing key, so no `KeyError`.

W3-M26 — d. Each call spawns two subtrees almost as large as itself; the call count grows by a factor of about the golden ratio, 1.618, per step of n .

Part B — Short answer and essay

W3-E1 (4) — writing `f` for `factorial`, the stack at each step, bottom → top (Lecture 03’s figure draws the same thing for `factorial(4)`):

Step	Stack	What happens
1	<code>f(3)</code>	calls <code>f(2)</code>

Step	Stack	What happens
2	f(3) f(2)	calls f(1)
3	f(3) f(2) f(1)	calls f(0)
4	f(3) f(2) f(1) f(0)	base case: f(0) returns 1
5	f(3) f(2) f(1)	$1 \times 1 = 1$; f(1) returns 1
6	f(3) f(2)	$2 \times 1 = 2$; f(2) returns 2
7	f(3)	$3 \times 2 = 6$; f(3) returns 6

Marking points: each call pushes a frame with its own n ; nothing is multiplied during winding; the base case stops the growth; each return pops a frame and the frame below finishes its multiplication; maximum depth $4 = n + 1$.

W3-E2 (4)

- `fib(n)` calls `fib(n-1)` **and** `fib(n-2)`; the recursion tree roughly doubles with each increase in n , because each node has two children almost as large as itself.
- The same subproblems are recomputed many times: in `fib(5)`, `fib(2)` is computed 3 times, `fib(3)` twice. Total calls $2 \text{fib}(n + 1) - 1$ — exponential, about 1.618^n ; `fib(30)` makes 2,692,537 calls.
- **Memoisation:** store each `fib(k)` in a memo Array the first time it is computed; later calls look it up. Each value is computed once.
- New cost: $O(n)$ time ($2n - 1$ calls — 59 for $n = 30$), $O(n)$ space for the memo plus $O(n)$ stack depth.

W3-E3 (3)

- **Recursion** when the data or the problem is recursive: trees, nested lists, grammars; divide and conquer (binary search, merge sort); branching searches (subsets, Hanoi, backtracking) — where it is clearer and the depth is small.
- **A loop** when the recursion would be one call per element of flat data, or the depth could be large.
- **Python concerns**, any two: the $\sim 1,000$ -frame recursion limit (`RecursionError`); no tail-call optimisation, so every call costs a frame; a function call is relatively slow in CPython; slicing inside recursion silently adds $O(n)$ per call.

W3-E4 (4)

- **Strategy** for n disks from A to C: move $n - 1$ disks A $\rightarrow$ B (recursively, using C as spare); move the largest disk A $\rightarrow$ C; move the $n - 1$ disks B $\rightarrow$ C (recursively, using A as spare). Base case: one disk, one move.
- **Recurrence:** $T(1) = 1, T(n) = 2T(n - 1) + 1$.
- **Solution:** $T(n) = 2^n - 1$ (unroll: 1, 3, 7, 15, ...; or the induction proof in W3-R5).
- **Minimum:** the largest disk must move at least once. At that moment all the other $n - 1$ disks must be on the spare peg — which takes at least $T(n - 1)$ moves — and afterwards they must all be moved back on top, at least $T(n - 1)$ more. So any solution needs at least $2T(n - 1) + 1$ moves: the exponential cost is in the problem, not the algorithm.

W3-E5 (3)

- When writing the recursive case, **assume** the recursive call correctly solves the smaller problem, and only ask how to build this answer from that one. Do not trace every call.
- This is **induction**: the base case is the induction base; “if the smaller call is right then this call is right” is the inductive step. Together they prove the function correct for every input the measure reaches.
- It only works if the base case is right and the recursive case really makes progress towards it.

W3-E6 (4)

- (a) **list** — ordered, grows by append in amortised $O(1)$, allows duplicates (two students can have the same mark).
- (b) **set** — “have I seen this ID?” is $O(1)$ on average against $O(n)$ for a list; duplicates are exactly what it prevents.
- (c) **dict** — $ID \rightarrow name$, $O(1)$ average lookup by key.
- (d) **tuple** — a fixed record of related values of different types; immutable, therefore hashable, so it can be a dictionary key or set member (a list cannot).

Part C — Recurrences

W3-R1. One call on a number with one digit fewer, $O(1)$ work: $T(1) = c$, $T(n) = T(n-1) + c \rightarrow T(n) = O(n)$ in the number of digits, i.e. $O(\log x)$ in the value x .

W3-R2. Two calls on $n-1$: $T(1) = c$, $T(n) = 2T(n-1) + c \rightarrow O(2^n)$. It returns 2^{n-1} (for $n \geq 1$): 1, 2, 4, 8, ... $O(n)$ **version** — call once, double the result:

```
def mystery(n):
    if n <= 1:
        return 1
    return 2 * mystery(n - 1)
```

$O(1)$ **version** (arithmetic on small numbers counted as $O(1)$): `return 2 ** (n - 1)` for $n \geq 1$, else 1. Recognising what a recursion *computes* can remove it entirely.

W3-R3. Two calls on halves, $O(1)$ work: $T(1) = c$, $T(n) = 2T(n/2) + c$. The recursion tree has $1 + 2 + 4 + \dots + n \approx 2n$ nodes, each $O(1)$: $O(n)$ — the same as a loop, not $O(n \log n)$ (that needs $O(n)$ work per call, as in merge sort). The stack depth is the height of the tree: $\log_2 n$, so $O(\log n)$ space — much less than a one-element-at-a-time recursion, which would need depth n .

W3-R4. `text[1:]` copies $n-1$ characters and the concatenation builds a string of length n : $O(n)$ work outside one call on $n-1$. $T(0) = c$, $T(n) = T(n-1) + cn \rightarrow O(n^2)$.

W3-R5. Claim: $T(n) = 2^n - 1$ for all $n \geq 1$.

- **Base:** $T(1) = 1 = 2^1 - 1$, true.
- **Step:** assume $T(k) = 2^k - 1$ for some $k \geq 1$. Then $T(k+1) = 2T(k) + 1 = 2(2^k - 1) + 1 = 2^{k+1} - 1$, as required.

- By induction the claim holds for every $n \geq 1$. ■

Part D — Trace the code and the call stack

W3-T1

19 7

g adds the digits: $4 + 0 + 9 + 6 = 19$. $g(7)$ is the base case.

W3-T2

1101 1 1000

The binary representations of 13, 1 and 8. The leading digits are built by the inner calls; each call appends its own last bit on the way back.

W3-T3

Call	$a \% b$	Returns
gcd(48, 18)	$48 \% 18 = 12$	6
gcd(18, 12)	$18 \% 12 = 6$	6
gcd(12, 6)	$12 \% 6 = 0$	6
gcd(6, 0)	base case	6

Maximum depth: **4** frames. Every frame returns the same value unchanged — a tail call, which is why gcd converts to a loop so easily.

W3-T4

8 25

$\text{fib}(6) = 8$; the call count is $2 \text{fib}(7) - 1 = 2 \times 13 - 1 = 25$.

W3-T5. $\text{hanoi}(2, \text{"A"}, \text{"C"}, \text{"B"})$: **A→B, A→C, B→C**. The moves of $\text{hanoi}(3, \text{"A"}, \text{"C"}, \text{"B"})$ are **A→C, A→B, C→B, A→C, B→A, B→C, A→C**: the 4th move is **A→C** — the largest disk, exactly in the middle.

W3-T6

[2, 1, 0, 1, 2] 11

Each level adds n on both sides of the inner result: length $2n + 1$, so 11 for $n = 5$.

W3-T7

```
{'the': 2, 'cat': 1, 'hat': 1}
the {3}
```

Dictionaries keep insertion order. Sorting the keys by negative count puts the first. The set comprehension removes duplicate lengths: all four words have 3 letters.

W3-T8

```
[3, 2, 1] 6 3
```

`__iter__` is a generator, and each `for/list()/sum()` calls it again, so the object can be iterated any number of times.

Part E — Find and fix the bug

W3-B1. For even n it makes **two** identical calls on $n/2$: $T(n) = 2T(n/2) + c$, which is $O(n)$ — the halving saves nothing. **Fix:** call once and reuse the result:

```
def power(x, n):
    if n == 0:
        return 1
    half = power(x, n // 2)
    result = half * half
    if n % 2 == 1:
        result = result * x
    return result
```

Now $T(n) = T(n/2) + c = O(\log n)$.

W3-B2. The base case returns `[]` — “there are no subsets” — so `rest` is always empty and so is every result: `subsets([1, 2])` returns `[]`. **Fix:** return `[[] ]` — the empty set has exactly one subset, the empty one.

W3-B3. Strings have `__iter__`, so “ab” is treated as a nested list; every character is itself a one-character string, which again has `__iter__`, and the function recurses into “a” for ever: `RecursionError`. **Fix:** descend only into lists: `if isinstance(item, list):`.

W3-B4. The recursive case computes the sum but does not **return** it, so every call except the base case returns `None`. `total([5])` gives `None`; `total([1, 2])` raises `TypeError: unsupported operand type(s) for +: 'int' and 'NoneType'`, one level above the base case. **Fix:** `return values[i] + total(values, i + 1)`.

Part F — Write the code**W3-C1**

```
def array_sum(arr, i=0):
    if i >= len(arr):
        return 0
    return arr[i] + array_sum(arr, i + 1)  # nothing left
```

W3-C2

```
def count_char(text, ch):
    if text == "":
        return 0
    return (1 if text[0] == ch else 0) + count_char(text[1:], ch)
```

Correct, but $O(n^2)$ because of the slice — pass an index to make it $O(n)$.

W3-C3

```
def is_sorted_rec(arr, i=0):
    if i >= len(arr) - 1:
        return True
    if arr[i] > arr[i + 1]:
        return False
    return is_sorted_rec(arr, i + 1)
```

zero or one element left

W3-C4

```
def no_consecutive_ones(n):
    def build(prefix, remaining):
        if remaining == 0:
            return [prefix]
        result = build(prefix + "0", remaining - 1)
        if not prefix.endswith("1"):
            result = result + build(prefix + "1", remaining - 1)
        return result
    return build("", n)
```

Counts for $n = 1, 2, 3, 4, 5$: **2, 3, 5, 8, 13** — the Fibonacci numbers. A valid string of length n either starts with 0 followed by any valid string of length $n - 1$, or starts with 10 followed by any valid string of length $n - 2$, so $\text{count}(n) = \text{count}(n - 1) + \text{count}(n - 2)$.

W3-C5

```
def pascal_row(n):
    if n == 0:
        return [1]
    previous = pascal_row(n - 1)
    middle = [previous[k - 1] + previous[k] for k in range(1, len(previous))]
    return [1] + middle + [1]
```

Each entry is the sum of the two above it. One recursive call per row: depth n , and $O(n^2)$ additions in total.